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EE 394 Ethics Essay

The purpose of following a Code of Ethics as an engineer is to guide action in accordance with the standards that are set in place for the sake of greater moral implications and consequences. Engineers make decisions that affect society in many complex ways, and we possess great knowledge and roles that the general populace are distanced from, thus we have a responsibility to act properly towards them. An example of a major ethical obligation is to treat other people as ends in themselves. Because each person views themselves as valuable, we should extend that logic to other people as well and understand that other people also view themselves as valuable. This is the basic premise of deontology, an ethical theory that guides actions towards adherence to rules and treating each person with dignity and self-worth. Deontology is directly related to an ethical agent such as an engineering being constrained to a Code of Ethics, because it outlines unbreakable rules that cannot be weighed against by other consequences.

An example for how this relates to professional action can be protecting user personal data. A person's privacy is a right that is protected and no matter the gain that would come from breaking their privacy, and a Code of Ethics, would explain why violating their rights is unethical. The ethical obligation to respect privacy as a result of consistency to the rule of not violating other's rights can be seen in other professions such as attorney-client privilege and doctor-patient confidentiality. Engineers are no different since we can never justify an action that would violate another is claim to their privacy and thus, we have that codified.

A specific example of an ethical issue that was discussed in class was a car company having a defective design that made it such that a collision at a specific part of the car made it so it was calculably more likely to ignite the car on fire. The company knew of this but had decided that the benefits of not recalling the cars and fixing the defect outweighed the costs of the human lives the accident took as well as other costs such as publicity and court fees. The reading material in class outlined the very basic calculation citing the $11 cost per unit of car nominally was greater than the cost of the human lives. I do not personally go about making ethical decisions with a specific process, but I generally try to be respectful and mindful of everyone and act in a way that I think is fair. The consensus I reached for this ethical problem is then different tan of some of my classmates. Some of my classmates argued that a company would be acting unfairly if they did not reduce the situation down to numbers since that is the most unbiased and purely evaluative process they can have, and they only consider cost-benefit in a very utilitarian way. I believe that a proper code of ethics should have forbade this from happening and can also be explained why this is improper using the IEEE code of ethics and the virtues of ethics.

The three virtues I think best explain why it would have been proper to recall the dangerous part despite it being less beneficial from a monetary cost-benefit analysis are Charity, Responsibility, and Integrity. I think all the virtues can be aligned with the right course of actions however I think these three are the most directly related to the justification the company employed. Charity is a virtue that would explain that the car company should have taken an action to save more lives and the expense of losing some money per the cost-benefit analysis because they can act in a way that is not only in their self-interest but in the interest of the public as well. Responsibility would explain that the company

should be accountable for the poor design and recognize that they made a mistake for the sake of acting for the good of the consumers. Integrity would explain that the company should have exercised good ethical judgement and in accordance with deontology would have understood that reducing human worth down to just numbers is very bad and can lead to very bad things for example slavery might be justified by a cost-benefit analysis but deontology is useful for recognizing why slavery is morally repugnant. Finally, I think IEEE code of ethics point 1, "to accept responsibility in making decisions consistent with the safety… of the public…" and point 9, "to avoid injuring others…" are directly related to this ethical problem as both say they should have recalled the design flaw in order to prioritize minimizing danger to the passengers.